The Heart Stone

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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Gen

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

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by B0ts

Summary

‘The cathedral bells shook the heavens. Glimmer glanced down at the writing on her skin, holding her tears back.

“I guess it’s my turn now,” ey muttered. The writing creeped to her cheeks followed by a piercing ache. She gave a weak smile.

“Thank you for this journey.”

“Thank you for believing in me.”’

For Aid. For Revenge. For Treasure. For Hope. A tale of four travellers seeking to make their greatest wishes come true in a world of no charity.

The Heart Stone: A Shera medieval au

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Gabriel I

“The king is dead!”

The crowd burst. A series of gasps and cries.

When the uproar faded, the held back sobs of a few remained. Some children cried softly too, others stared in uncertainty. Then there were the wiser ones, who chose not to cry at all.

The messenger droned on, “Upon finding ashed remains, on the west outskirts of the woods, King Micah has been declared dead as of this date.”

The queen readjusted her collar and her gown whispered behind her up the platform. Her lips parted, an aching silence in place of speech. “We honour his legacy in the fight for justice,” she choked.

Her lips started to quiver.

“Long live the king!”

“Long live the king!”

“Long live the king…”

Cheek pressed against the balustrade, her nails carved circles into the stone. Ey muttered the cry out into the air. A last wish as if ready to surrender the resistance that once fueled her, that lingered on eir words, to an unforgiving god.

“Heaven’s Circle.” ey whispered. The shapes beneath her fingers lit and halos of gold light danced with the wind in one breath.

Jolting in a panic, the princess smothered the illusion. Tilting a glance across both shoulders, she brought herself closer to her palms and peaked. An entranced daze swept over her. A crooked

smile tugging at her face. Hypnotised and brought back to life with the humble display of splendor.

“I did it.”

“Your majesty,” a shriek pierced the heavens. The princess swooped eir hand across the ledge and turned in one swift motion to her advisor. “am I wrong to believe your mother detained you in your room?”

The princess tugged at her tunic nervously, “Uh, I don’t think so,” she took notice of the word and immediately changed the subject, “wait... have my grievances with the title, ‘princess’, not been expressed?”

“Such a title is only necessary your majesty, howbeit I shall abide by your wishes...Glimmer…” Glimmer smiled.

“Thank you!” Glimmer turned on one heel to study the crowd again, “ You may proceed.”

“Is your stance not all too blithe for an heir under detention? You’ve been instructed to remain in the castle and yet you disobey orders to observe the meeting.”

“Why I wouldn’t miss it for the world! The great unveiling of the king’s death,” Glimmer raved, a sharp, poisonous edge to eir cheerful tone. “Have I not been graced with enough liberty as to mourn with the kingdom?”

“I suppose so your highness...however the queen would not be pleased upon spotting you underdressed.”

Glimmer felt eir heel knock at her ankle. Glancing down at her plain blue tunic and trousers, eir radiant smile stretched into pursed lips briefly. “Very well,” she shrugged, facing the guard, “perhaps I shall take heed and remain in my room after all.”

“You do not resist?”

“In the face of the queen? Not today.”

Glimmer carried eirself past the bewildered guard, her face powdered with foolish joy.

~~~

“And The Book of Royal Etiquette.”

“Yes.”

“And the guide your mother so graciously prepared for *you.*”

“Yes...”

“And a letter...from a member of the royal army, an admirer most likely.”

“Ah...yes…” Glimmer’s face coiled.

The exchange settled to an awkward silence as Glimmer pivoted clumsily. She waited, but the advisor spoke no more. Phew.

“Oh and don’t-“

“Okay, thank you!” Ey shut the door with a backwards kick.

The tower of books wobbled at her every tumbling step. Quickening her pace as ey began to lose balance, the books sprawled themselves against the silk of eir bed. Throwing herself with them, she sunk into the lilac cloud.

Glimmer felt the weight on eir shoulders fade to dust, but grew sick at the rising ache in her chest. One hell for another. It had always been like that. Either the world that worked so hard to mould eir into the flawless princess she was meant to be, or the searing conflicts within em.

The ceremony? Perhaps.
~~~

A child that had long forgotten the disappearance of her father. In a world where vessel-less creatures ate away at the land and its inhabitants , searching for one hour, one day, one year...one decade...and more, ultimately accepting that there was nothing to be found. No pot of gold in the cave of beasts. No miracle in this land of magic…

And so today was the day the kingdom gave their last breath of hope. A lid to the empty pot.

Ey had just turned fifteen when she found herself in the same state, but now, ten years later, her mind raced searching for an answer for the pain between her ribs.

No.

He's not coming back.

Glimmer straightened eirself, sitting upright on the bed. Ey inhaled. A newfound passion burned within her. She made her way to the dresser, a strange thing adorned with pearls and golden moon carvings. She sought out for the frilliest dress ey could find.

~~~

The crowd cleared and the town had restored itself to its former bustling glory. Merchants selling the fruits of their labour. Smiths forging iron cast ornaments. Children skipping around bards as their music breathed life into the kingdom. What had been a ghostly despair faded just as quickly as it appeared. Life moved on.

Still, a loud thud shook the idle pigeons to flight.

The streets were cleared. The sounds of the kingdom tamed while the tremor grew more and more and more vicious. Stillness.
~~~

A swarm of lilac prodded past. Velvet flags embroidered with the king's emblem. Cheers and exasperated waves to welcome the men in silver. A wave of pride that left off with it the stench of dust. The knights rode off toward the castle.

The second roar from the gates put every villager back in their previous place.

Back at the barracks, the knights eased into the training courts, a large armoury jutting out the back gates with a clear view of the castle just up ahead. The sun embraced the enclosure, welcoming them home.

"You return in such a hurry?" She wondered, pausing her introspection to attend to the approaching commander.

"Captain, just who I needed to see." The knight dismounted and unmasked themself. The sun kissed his nose and reflected off his hazel gaze. Even in distress did Bow have a way of bringing solace to anyone lucky enough to cross his path, but now, the gold in his irises tarnished.

"Upon... our patrol we came across...*this.*"

He revealed three garnet ores in his gloved hands, red veins pulsing in between their cracks and crevices. Juliet lowered the cloth in her hands.

"Magic?"

"It has to be."

"I'll have Castaspella seal them off then. Work of the new rebel?"

"No, the one in the white cape doesn't use magic. This can only be the work of the Horde." Bow lowered the intricacies into Juliet's gloved hand. She turned and placed them onto the cloth she used to polish the swords.

“Where did you manage to find them?” she continued, focused on tying a good enough knot, “East of Greenfield? Thaymor?”

Bow gripped on the band across his chest.

“Under the north bridge.”

+++

Angella kept her eyes on the page. “Alright.”

Still tense from anticipation, Glimmer opened her eyes and relaxed her shoulders. “ Oh...well, great.”

The two remained in silence for a while, save for the occasional clinking of the ink bottle.

“Um,” Glimmer hesitated, “you spoke well at the gathering today.”

Nothing.

Glimmer gulped, “I’ll be on my way then.” She quickly averted back to the halls and out of the sharp study. It took a little longer for Glimmer to make out the benefits of their exchange, as awkward as it made her feel. Ey had just asked to leave the castle and her mother had said nothing. *Nothing.*No condition or rule or curfew or law. Her eagerness burned like a firestorm and-

“Uh, Glimmah, I’ll be assigning a guard to escort you. You will not be out for more than three hours.”

-and...burned out. Glimmer let out a familiar sigh.

“Alright Ma.”

***

A guard! *A guard!*An escort with the entire royal coach was not *a guard!*

“Stop! Stop.”

The horses whined at their halt.

“Your majesty, is everything alright?”

She threatened to pull at her hair, “No nothing is- I’m going to walk!”

“On foot?! But your majesty the queen-”

“The *queen* requested nothing of this sort. At least not to me. I’ll do fine on my own, but if you must, one escort is enough.” Glimmer fumbled over the hems of eir gown out of the coach.

“Now look at that.” ey raised an arm, “I originally planned to take Loo-Kee for a walk but he’s held to the royal coach!” She sighed, “Just... don’t worry yourselves then. I’ll take him around another time.”

The ensemble trudged like defeated troops, their heads low and shoulders sunken. Glimmer waved briefly.

“Right, let’s stop by the marketplace,” Glimmer huffed.

The two ventured along the busy path. The princess watched as her citizens cleared from her path, like she possessed a deadly omen, all averting their gaze with great deference. It stung, but Glimmer had been wise enough to familiarise herself with the feeling.

Although it never used to be like this.

The hum of the crowds grew feint. The stalls framing the walkway grew scarce. Glimmer turned into a quiet alley, where the sun struggled to reach between the narrow walls.

" Your majesty, I don't think this is a very safe route." She crept deeper

"Yes. That's why you're here not so?" Glimmer mused.

Ey came to a complete stop in front of a stone wall. "Well, " she turned to the guard, "I think we're lost."

Glimmer tried hard to contain the giggle at her escort's brief sigh. They always fell for it.

"I suppose we'll just have to trace our way back to- Mph!?"

"Shhh," Glimmer held a clothed palm to the escorts mouth, focused on the glowing spheres that grew beyond her hands. "Think green meadows, blue skies aaaand…" her head ached the further the incantation drew, "sleep."

Glimmer panicked when the escort fell forward, rushing to stop them mid fall. She cursed under her breath before wasting any more time.

She dusted her hands off, chuffed at her effort to get the escort to sleep comfortably on some supply fabric. She wondered why no one had noticed the back of the textile workshop.

The princess no longer wore a violet gown or a bedecked headdress. In fact, this was not the princess at all, but Glimmer. Glimmer and Glimmer alone. An aspiring mage in a white tunic, velvet tights and oversized leather boots. Ey removed a worn book from her belt pouch, treading her hands over the diamond embossing before opening to aged pages. "Hm, not bad." It was filled with scribbles, notes, checklists beside spell sketches and otherwise illegible writing. "Alignment was a bit off this time but I think I've got the hang of it." She shoved it back in her pouch and pinched the timer on her wrist. "Sixty minutes left and...start the countdown."

Back to the busy streets of Brightmoon, Glimmer took in the smells of the orchards and the rush of freedom. The sun shone

brighter, the music sang louder and the world felt completely new. Ducking and squeezing through crowds, watching her step as to not get run over by the approaching carts. Trying to memorise the steps of this inner city dance on her way to the market square.

Yes, in this world she was invisible. Utterly invisible and free from the weight of perception.

“Uh, sorry…” Glimmer mumbled, bumping into a figure. Past the chatter of the two taller men in front of her, eir plea fell unheard. “Um, hello!?” Completely blocking eir path to the market square, they carried on. She groaned.

There were ways to resolve the issue quickly, but ey knew better as to not bring attention to eirself.

That’s when she took note of the hay cart heading in the same direction.

+++

She shook herself out of a daze when the cart stopped, not realizing she had snugged up against the hay. The belt around the bails fell to her feet. It was time to go.

She hopped off and creeped away, into the circle of the market place. The sun reflected off the emerald glass hanging from one of the booths and onto the mural floor. “Forty off fresh mackerel! Forty off fresh mackerel! Straight from Seaworthy!” were only a few lines part of the market chorus. Glimmer smiled.

Toward the quieter side of the venue was her usual stop. She turned around the corner eagerly. A glimpse of the doors wiped the smile clean from eir face. She squinted at the letters, reading ‘closed’, painted on the bakery windows.

“Looking for someone?” Glimmer peered at the shopkeeper, lifting up crates of fruit. “That place’s been closed for a couple of days now.”

“What- what happened?” Ey queried.

“Oh, it’s nothing new. Turns out the guy running the place got bit, caught straight onto the virus. Must have ventured too far outside of Brightmoon I guess…”

The world spun. The words couldn’t register past her ear drums.

Glimmer had never gone to the bakery to buy bread. Perhaps there was the off chance she would get something for eir and her ma. She had no relations to the baker at all, only that he knew about her. One other soul who still had an ounce of hope for a disregarded power. She shoved the book further into her belt. There were no words left to say.

The orchards lost their scent on eir way back. The sun hid herself. There was less purpose to the mage’s steps. She saw the world through grey tinted glasses. A far more realistic view to the former.

Ey stumbled into the alley where she left her escort and altered into the Glimmer they had last seen, the princess. She leaned in, glancing at the timer she kept hold of. A matter of time anyway.

The guard jolted awake. “Your-“

“It seems you weren’t feeling well. I’m fine.” She didn’t bother elaborating.

“I’d like to go home now.”

Gabriel II

A universe of dust and paper. The library spanned for metres on end. Dusk withered on its edge and a cool light stretched across the oak floor. The hall was filled with the aroma of damp paper from the morning haze.

The wood piece screeched on the board. Angella stood over the map, muttering to herself in deep thought. She moved another piece, this one closer to the meadows, and a third one at the mouth of Brightmoon's east bridge. Slowly lifting her finger off the wooden horse figure, she scanned her work one more time and finally stood back.

A map etched onto the library desk reached as far as the colossal bay window across the room.

She lifted a finger to her lip with crossed arms. Her last scan brought her attention to the knight piece on the border of the woods. She leaned to it, but hovered above the piece soon swirling her hand. She dragged it back to Brightmoon.

"Ma." Angella jumped at the sudden thud. Right in the middle of Salineas sat 'A Guide to Being a Better Princess'.

Glimmer spoke with a straight face, "I've read over everything. Twice…"

"Headress?"

"Further back."

"Bowl?"

"In hand."

"Arms?"

"In front of you, always."

The corner of Angella's lips lifted. "Very well, then you can read the second one I left in the solar for you."

Glimmer's mouth fell to the floor. Ey groaned and tumbled to the chair, eir head banging on the table.

"Don't be so dramatic." Angella attended to the pieces that had toppled over. " I'm not giving you anything new. Those are the same rules I adhered to at your age, most probably even younger." Glimmer remained with her face flat on the table. Realizing her words dissolved to dust for the princess, Angella carried on with the map.

The melody of wood tapping wood echoed across the library. There was not another sound for a fair moment or two. Angella rested her head on her hand, calculating her next move. Curious, the princess peeked through the sliver between her arms.

Glimmer lifted her head slowly. "What are you doing?"

"I'm planning a line of defence. I don't like how quiet the Horde's been," her mother replied.

"Hm," Glimmer glossed over the board, "is that your plan?"

"At the moment."

Glimmer nodded. She watched her mother closely. Knight to Greenfield. Chivalry to Meadowlands. Archers to west gate. A layered border tactic. Strong, but not strong enough.

"Well, if I may," ey reached for all the pieces and slid them right back to Brightmoon, "we know the horde is situated on the west, our most vulnerable gate."

"Yes."

"but the only way to that gate is through the Whispering Woods, and not even the horde is dumb enough to cross a thicket like that."

“Glimmah what-.”

“Wait, just hear me out.” At this point Glimmer had been hovering over the map, her hands moving the pieces like clockwork and fully absorbed in eir tactics. Like this, ey reminded her mother so much of him.

“So use the land,” ey finally explained, “ Divide your chivalry between the south and west, more around Thaymor and...Mystacor” she choked on the last syllable. Angella shifted. “If the horde manages to muster any soldiers across we wouldn’t be over armed. We could border the gates with the archers, but at least we’d be making more use of our geological advantage this way.”

Angella tilted her head. Perhaps that could work.

“But you haven’t positioned your knights,” she enquired.

Glimmer lit up. Her grand finale. Ey slid the knights across to the north.

“Dryl? But that’s-“

“Yes. An attack right in the face of the Horde!”

Angella sprung up. “No no no no our knights don’t even amount to about a tenth of the entire Horde army. That’s reckless.” Glimmer watched her mother reposition the knights to the south in dismay.

“Buuuut, ” Glimmer swooped the figures close to eir side again, “that doesn’t mean they can’t deal enough damage. The Talon Mountains are full of narrow creeks. They’d be approachable if we squeeze them out. It’s not reckless.”

“Glimmah, that’s enough.” And to the south again.

“What do you mean that’s enough?” A few knights toppled over upon moving to the north. “We’re stuck in a stalemate Ma! We

need to do something for once!”

“That’s enough young lady.”

“What would She-ra be doing in the meadowlands?! It’s not like the Horde’s at our doorstep!”

“I said that’s *enough*!”

Glimmer froze.

Angella’s frown thawed upon looking at the board. Every piece toppled over from the slam of her hand. She composed herself.

“I can’t-“ her lips pressed thin, eyes glued to the board. “ Brightmoon can’t afford anymore loss. You may not understand now but I know what I’m doing.”

Glimmer tugged at eir trousers and nodded. She wasted no more time and headed for the door, book in hand.

+++

The day had been just as busy as the last. Glimmer sat on the window ledge and crunched into eir apple.

“Oh yeah,” ey muffled, “I can’t believe they’re coming home today.” She took another bite.

“Thank god I don’t live near the Inn. Those hooligans sure know how to throw a party.” Juliet added, leaning further into the ledge. They both watched the streets of Brightmoon from the sidelines.

“Well, thanks for getting me out of there. I’d start kicking in the walls if I stayed any longer.” Glimmer found herself biting into the core. Slightly taken aback, ey tossed it into the nearest bush.

“It’s not a problem.”

Glimmer sighed looking down at her swaying leather boots. Juliet knew about the adventurer that roamed as far as the kingdom streets, but not the mage. Occasionally, on the days she wasn't training the up and coming knights, she'd volunteer to escort Glimmer around Brightmoon, giving eir enough freedom to wander off on eir own. Yes, ey still kept a part of herself hidden, but at least there had been some form of a bright side.

"I'll be on my way then. Meet you back here in an hour," ey announced. She hopped off and joined the wave of crowds.

"Hey." Glimmer looked back.

"Your mother just wants you to be safe. Alright?"

The violet haired mage nodded briefly, but didn't care to give a proper response.

She pushed against the current. Word spread that a new artisan store had just opened and Glimmer had grown tired of her worn out ink bottle. "I hope they have something cute," ey thought.

Wooden beams perched on the mossed wall. "No kidding." Someone had already been busy carving a sign out for the store, telling from the work table outside the door.

Ding! "Hello?"

No one at the desk, but a cramped library full of glass trinkets and novelties. Glimmer entered in awe.

A muffled thud came from the back. "Coming...oof!" Another thud. The curtains shrieked open. "Sorry, we're still a little busy settling in," they rubbed their forehead, "How can I be of assistance?"

Glimmer stared blankly at the messy haired shopkeeper before looking at the shelves again. "This is really beautiful work you have here. They're all yours?"

“Correct. It’s only my first day here in Brightmoon, so excuse me if I’m curious as to already having a customer. Has the word already spread of the strange girl with the glass workshop?” Her skin radiated teal.

“Not entirely. I mean I don’t find this strange.” Glimmer inspected the wine vase with its detailed dragon relief curling around it. “Maybe that makes me strange too.” Ey put it back on the shelf. “But I’m looking for-“

“Have they found it? The Heart?” A much older person with similar features peaked out of the curtain, “We must find the Heart to save us all.” The sculpter took fright. Glimmer’s attention perked.

“No, not yet. Hey, I have a new piece I’d like to share. Do you mind waiting for me in the workshop? I’ll be with you now.” She led them behind the curtain.

“Everything okay?”

“Mhm.” Her indigo eyes said otherwise. “Apologies for the interruption. That’s just my grandpa.”

Glimmer studied a petite ink bottle decorated with celestial shapes and stained glass. Ey held it to the light and the glass had turned into an assortment of jewels. Perfect.

Ey was pleased with her discovery, but something still troubled her deeply on the way to the counter. Heart. *Heart*. The word bounced around in eir skull.

“This one’s my favourite! You have a good eye for design.” She snapped out of her head and noticed the sculptor again.

Glimmer felt the tug at her tights.

“Um, I’m really sorry but- do you mind if I ask about the ‘Heart’ your grandfather spoke of.”

The sculptor’s face flushed.

“Ohhh ah, eee...nevermind. Nevermind I’m-“

“No it’s alright.” She flashed Glimmer a heavy smile.

She stood upright, polishing the ink bottle with a cloth. “Some gemstone that grants wishes, he says. It’s just a comforting myth written up for the children.” She paused. “He used to be a part of a great team of knights you know? His greatest companions. They sought out to find it in one last attempt to end the war.”

“Then- what happened.”

“He never found it...but he lost every single one of his friends.” Her gaze on the bottle was stone cold.

“I couldn’t imagine all the death he’s seen. I- I’m sure that was his breaking point. He never let the dream of it go...”

Glimmer’s face softened at the tale. Perhaps it would have been better not to ask.

“Don’t let it upset you. Curse of seeking magic I suppose.” Huh, appropriate response. She offered the bottle and Glimmer took it gently in her hands.

“Yeah.”

The doorbell rang on eir way out. “Thank you! I hope to see you again soon! Bye!”

+++

It was if the land and the sky had switched places. Those new to the sight could have easily mistaken the golden lanterns for the presence of stars, but only one light took up the navy stage. Brightmoon’s moon looked even more beautiful in her completion as she smiled on the weary city.

The barracks however were dim, too quiet for any nuance of life. Glimmer adjusted eir hood and carried on through the maze of alleyways and bridges. Ey cursed upon reaching the courtyard.

She expected to see him perched over the well, but the structure stood eerily alone in the center.

Ey sighed.

“Hey!” She approached the knight on watch duty. “I’m looking for someone around here. Tall, blonde, usually has his helmet on.” She spoke the last words slowly to tell if the guard had picked up on anything.

They gave their full attention to the mage.

“You mean the gold knight? Of course I know about him!”

“Oh no. You sound like a fan.”

“I look up to him. Who wouldn’t? He’s a great leader off and on the field.”

“I really don’t have time for this just tell me where he i-“

“He barely takes off that helmet when out in public, and he’s always helping out here in the barracks no matter how tired you’d think he is, but try getting him something to say thanks. He expects nothing but gives everything. What a humble soul.”

+++

“Aha!” Their cupped fists hit the table with a bang. “What. a. surprise. It looks like I won...again. Rules are rules. You owe everyone here a drink.” The Inn erupted with laughter and praise. The blonde knight smirked through his tresses and lay out his hand, a supporter giving him a passionate high-five.

The man on the other end sat small, looking meek and humbled by his loss. “I- I can’t afford that much.”

“Is that sooo? From your razor sharp commentary I assumed you were pretty comfortable with the terms. Truly a good leader evaluates the risks they’re taking before jumping into battle, or has my youthful lens deceived me?” The crowd ‘ooh’d’. The man lowered his head in shame.

The blonde knight sighed. He rose from his chair and walked to the other side, gently placing his hand on the man’s shoulder.

“Don’t let it tarnish your spirit, you have a great one, but don’t question my strength again.” He let his hand fall to his side.

“Get everyone here a drink, and put it on me!” Everyone cheered.

Bow watched him strut to their table with wide eyes. “You’re ridiculous.”

“What? Sorry. Perhaps I overreacted.”

“I’m not talking about your little dual I’m talking about the three digit bill on your plate.”

Adora pouted and sunk into his chair. “Well I promised everyone something…”

“Not from you,” Bow commented. Adora cringed sheepishly at the paper in front of him.

Three Towers was always at its busiest after an expedition. The knights of this age used it for celebration, and so did the knights before them, and the knights before that. “A shame that the tradition would have to come to an end,” Glimmer thought, poking her head through the door.

Adora lit up upon spotting the hooded ghost.

“Huh! Glim- “ He froze under Bow and Glimmer’s synchronised glare, “-mmmmm my dearest friend! Hehe, buddy…” He waved his hands awkwardly in response to the curious looks. Glimmer sluggishly dragged a chair from an empty table.

“Well, you’re very late.” Adora shifted his chair closer to Bow.

“And you’re not at your outpost,” she sunk to her seat “so I guess everyone’s just full of surprises.”

Bow and Adora exchanged looks. “You okay?”

“No, if I run into another one of your fanboys I might rip my ears off. *I* didn’t even know you hold your sword with your pinkie out.” Adora sulked.

“Phew, but that doesn’t matter. We’re all together now.” The glitter in Glimmer’s rose eyes returned. “Tell me *everything*.”

Before Adora could get a word out, the waiter placed two jugs on the table. “Oh. Thank you.” He slid Bow’s across and began, “Well, there was nothing different really,” finishing off with a sip.

“What?! You guys are always shoving stuff in my face,” she carried on with a sarcastic tone, “like how you got cornered unprepared that one time but sent half of the soldiers home crying ,” Glimmer turned to Bow “or how you cleared half of the woods of Shadow demons with just Kowl alone.”

“You remember that? Not that time we got ambushed by ninety of those guys and I had to take them all on on my own. I even turned my sword into a lance! Boring.” Adora played along.

“And speaking of Kowl,” Bow placed his bow on the table, “I’ve finally got the dimensions on him right for shots with the new gunpowder arrows. There’s officially no way the horde can get past the two of us.” Bow pouted as he spoke in a mockingly proud tone. The archer and knight gave up their jest and laughed amongst themselves.

Glimmer sat back in her chair, mouth agape. “You two are unbearable.”

Bow settled. “Okay, okay, but on a more serious note,” Bow continued, “I have something to report.” He took a brief sip, “

Yesterday, at the ceremony, I found a few pieces of Horde magic on patrol."

"What? Where?"

"Right under the north bridge. That's alarmingly close don't you think?"

Adora's face sunk. "Hm. Weird."

"That you hold your pinkie out when holding your sword? Yea I'd like to know how that works too," Glimmer teased.

"Leave my sword etiquette out of this! I'm talking about the Horde artifacts." Glimmer suppressed a chuckle with a hand over eir mouth.

"It is weird. We looked at them more closely with Aunt Casta and found that they were explosives, but not just any explosives, ones infused with the same incantations of the Red Plague." The mage's ears perked up at the word. Ey felt her heart sink to her stomach.

Adora's expression mirrored hers. "Woah woah, but that means-"

"Yep, if they had gone off, half of Brightmoon would have been infected. We wouldn't have stood a chance."

The mood of the table pivoted.

"Super spreaders of a virus that grants certain death. Who would have thought they'd stoop to that, huh?" Glimmer gulped, her head spinning to the news she had received yesterday. She clenched her tights.

"I- It's fine. It's *fine*." Adora made his attempt to lift the mood. "Nothing went off and we're ten times smarter now that we were able to investigate it. The Horde doesn't have one up on us just yet."

Adora darted between Bow and Glimmer, looking for any sign of reaction.

“Yea, you’re right,” Glimmer reassured, but it was clear she didn’t really believe it. Ey gave Adora a small smile anyway and lowered her eyes to the table. Adora sat back in his chair, defeated.

Her nail traced a beautiful carving. A fierce dragon winding around in the center of the circular surface. A symbol of resistance in times of great suffering.

“You know what? Hey!” It was as if a switch had been turned to change Glimmer’s mood. Ey caught the attention of a passing waiter. “Get me one of those...please.” The waiter nodded, following Glimmer’s insinuation to the jug in Adora’s hand. Both Bow and Adora gave eir a curious look.

“Um, are you sure about that? This is pretty strong and not exactly...a drink for a princess.” Adora whispered the last words.

“And? Princess that, knight this, I’m capable of drinking whatever I want.” The waiter arrived just in time. Glimmer chugged down the drink and brought it back down to the table with a bang, staring Bow and Adora dead in the eyes. The two watched eir carefully.

Glimmer’s cheeks puffed as tears formed in her eyes. Her face caved in on itself. “It’s- It’s great,” she choked.

Silence.

All three of them burst out in laughter. The mage hadn’t realized how good it felt to see her friends again after several months. She didn’t want to think about war, or the Horde, just this, the Best Friend Squad.

“No, Adora is right! They may have an army of Shadow Demons, and hundreds of soldiers, but Brightmoon has the best archer in Etheria, a mage on eir way to becoming the strongest in the land,” she whispered, “ and, drumroll please... sheeee-RA, She-RA, SHE-

RA-" Bow and the rest of the crowd joined in. "SHEE-RA, SHE-RA, SHE-RA!" Adora accepted the praise with a polite wave.

The night wasted away like that. Adora told dynamic tales of his great solo encounters with the Horde soldiers and the Shadow Beasts. Bow revealed the new projects and inventions he had been working on, getting a little too deep into the talk of physics and mechanics from time to time. Glimmer ranted on about the weight of royal upbringing, going as far as to mention the letter ey received and disregarded before opening.

"Oh god, I'm already running out of time. I better head back to the library before anyone gets suspicious." Bow briefly checked the clock hanging from the wooden strut. He stood up and collected Kowl off the table. "We shall meet again!" A quick thumbs-up and he had vanished.

Adora's eyes softened. " I guess we should get going too."

+++

The city streets were hauntingly poetic at night. The air was fresh, sweet and the crickets sang their evening song. Glimmer peeked up at Adora, wondering if he felt the same, or if his familiarity with freedom had desensitised him to the scene.

Between all three of them, Adora possessed the most of it. Freedom. No curfews, no one judging his every move. She couldn't deny the pinch of jealousy she held.

"You should be more careful...out there that is."

"Hm?"

"I'm just saying. I know you're different, but you're still human."

"Oh pfft." He brought his hands up to the back of his head. "Glimmer, don't worry about me. Being human doesn't mean a thing when you're magic. I've finally got the hang of all this. You can trust me."

Trust.

Of course ey trusted Adora.

Everyone trusted Adora.

“Besides…I’m honoured to be She-ra. The least I could do is live up to that.”

The images flashed in her consciousness. The meeting in the woods, the eyes in the fire...

“Mhm, you’re right.”

No. She’d rather not remember that either.

A boom echoed from behind them. “Huh? Adora?! Hiiii!” They both turned to see a girl, waving enthusiastically from her window.

Glimmer had sworn there had been confusion, but from the way Adora forced a smile and rubbed the back of his neck, clearly ey was the one that misunderstood.

“Ha, hey...uh-“

“I hope you had a wonderful day! Maybe- maybe we can see each other again sometime?” She hadn’t even stopped to receive an answer when a voice summoned her from inside. “Ok! Bye Adora!” She blew a kiss. Glimmer fought the chuckle tugging at her lips, conflicted between total shock and second hand embarrassment.

“Now... what’s going on *there*?”

“Calm down it was one night.” He replied through gritted teeth.

“Oooh? Your distractions are starting to worry me Adora.”

“I don’t ha- god why is the castle so damn far?!” Adora strode faster and faster away. Glimmer finally released a snicker.

+++

Sweet home. Home at last. The bed sheets embraced him on his fall.

His unit in the barracks hadn’t been any different from the others, a comfortable but modest loft. He groaned against the pillow.

The liminal whisper of the powder blue gem burned, calling him over and over again. Seeing his reflection in the crystal blade made his stomach churn, the mark like a hideous stamp on his being.

It’s not enough.

He buried his head further into the pillow.

Gabriel III

Chapter Notes

Content Warning:
Gruesome description of animal death.

Please read with caution.

Breathy huffs against cold vapour. The red orb lighting dawn bled over the horizon as the sky turned pink and teal.

Cool iron smeared the air. The sword swivelled in his hands in tune with his steps. He repeated his movements, stepping forward, lifting his thumb, circling his sword and... stuttered mid hit. "Ugh!" Adora growled in frustration. "Focus."

So he did it again, and again, until it had all become a familiar dance to him.

Exactly...

It's just like dancing.

He eyed the pell, circling it like a snake around its prey. At first he focused on his steps and his motion with the sword. Slowly adjusting his movements into one fluid coordination. Nothing else stood in space other than him and his target, completely entranced within his own concentration.

The sword slashed through the air faster as he moved in tune with the rhythm of combat. He moved with more speed, finally getting comfortable and without a jitter in his step until-

Slash! The world returned...and by then it was too late. The severed top slid off, falling to the ground with a thump. The remains of the pell emitted a dangerous smog like burnt rubber.

“Not another one!” Flutterina chimed. Fae sat behind the key counter “I’m not really an expert at sword training but,” fae paused to let out a yawn, ‘I don’t think you’re supposed to break the training equipment.”

Adora let the sword drop to his side, failing to hide his sudden embarrassment, “ Uh- I- Are you comfortable talking to me like that?”

“It’s almost 5am sir. I’m not entirely in the best headspace to answer that yet. ..Why am I on morning duty again?” fae buried her head in faer arms.

Honestly, he never understood that either. Moth Faeries weren’t very pleased with the idea of early morning work, hence many took nighttime positions and jobs that other citizens struggled with. Either way, Flutterina had learned to grow all too accustomed to Adora’s early mornings.

“Heh, teenagers.”

The pink bunned faerie lifted faer head with a ditzy smile. “Training never waits for you does it?” Adora emerged from the back gates with a fresh new pell.

“Well, She-ra doesn’t come at no cost, doesn’t it?” There was no time for him to really evaluate the clarity of his answer now that it was out in the open. He fitted the new pell into the cavity between the cobblestones and wiped the sweat off his forehead before picking up his sword again.

“Well can you ask She-ra if it has a sleep schedule by any chance? Seeing you train is super insightful, but I think it would be even more so if I wasn’t half-awake.” Fae held out a set of keys to which Adora accepted gratefully. He made his way through the complex gates while Flutterina rested faer head.

“Don’t tell your boss!”

“I didn’t see a thing!”

+++

Brightmoon had sprung to life with the radiance of its sun, one of the few moons that reflected travelling light from space unlike the others. It was an interesting phenomena that no one truly understood, but such a magical sensation gave the kingdom its name and glory.

Adora hauled the rope from the pulley, bringing the pail up to the third floor.

“Where’s that bucket for W23?!”

“Here!” Adora unclipped the handle and dismounted the water bucket with two hands, tripping and recovering before the water spilled across the bridge. He carried it through to the other side of the floor and clipped it onto another pulley, hauling it up until it reached steady hands.

The barracks were framed entirely different to the rest of Brightmoon. Structured vertically to save space, it was an assortment of stairs, bridges on top of bridges and ropes that carried water buckets from different points, to which Glimmer got easily frustrated by. Adora had gotten used to the architecture, becoming a cog in the grand wooden machine. It hadn’t been to everyone’s taste surely, but he grew fond of the sense of community. His throat caved at the memory.

He thought he had that once.

“W15, W18- no, W16, W1- huh? Who was in charge of W17?!”

“Hey, hey its okay. I had W17 delivered myself. You can tick it off.” Her antennae fell in relief at Adora’s consolation. He hadn’t actually asked for the (former) mayor of Elberon’s name, so he was relieved this had marked the third time they didn’t pick up his flippant greeting.

“Oh, alright. That’s good, everything’s in order, everything’s in...order.” Not even a minute had passed until she glued her eyes

into their notebook, hurtling in the other direction.

Adora pulled a condoling smile, making his way back to the main bridge and hauled another bucket. He carried on with his task, zipping from different pulley points and distributing water throughout the barracks.

In his rush, the stair tunnel echoed with heavy steps. The echoing stopped, but the heavy breathing from behind caught his attention. Adora stopped, three buckets in hand, to look at the figure tiredly leaning on the wall.

“Oh. Look who decided to show up.”

Bow rested one hand on his knee, with the other against the threshold. “Who? Me?” He spoke between breaths.

“Yes, you. You bailed on me this morning again. No wonder you’re so out of shape.”

He let out one last breath before lifting himself up. “I *know* that wasn’t really considerate of me and I apologize, but I have a very good excuse. In fact, you would notice I do a lot if you would just take a mo-”

“Solo training works and all, but a dual wouldn’t hurt anyone...or are you just avoiding me because you worry your sword fighting doesn’t match your archery skills?”

Adora received an equally amused as annoyed grin from the archer.

“I’m kidding.” The blonde returned a soft smirk. He lifted the buckets and carried on working.

“Flutter told me you’ve been training since three, yet you’re here like you just woke up. Aren’t you tired?”

“Nope.”

Bow crossed his arms and frowned as if he had just been insulted. " *Here we go,"* Adora thought.

"Adora. You just came back from seventeen weeks of cold nights, endless horde soldiers and what's probably enough emotional and physical heavy lifting for a year…" he rebutted, "I think someone could do with a day off."

"I don't like where this conversation is going…"

Bow chose not to say a word and instead held out an aged, rolled up piece of paper. Adora shot a perplexed glance, dropping the water pails before giving it a look himself.

"Oh...OH!"

"Dig deep and you'll find treasure."

"Bow you found this underground?" Adora probed, rolling his eyes eagerly over the document.

"No it's an ex-" Adora brought it to the sun, too ingrained to take note of Bow, "Nevermind."

The light revealed a string of markings and shapes, only a language Adora could decipher. Bow had added his research on the side, as well as a few sketches of what could be a great advantage to Brightmoon.

"I'll get Glimmer on this, so, consider giving yourself a break...for something fun like old times, please?"

Adora dropped the paper and looked at Bow, contemplating the idea. He couldn't help the contagious smile that curled up upon being trapped in his puppy eyes. "Alright alright! You win. I'll get someone to fill in for me and call off noon training."

Bow beamed, whispering a quiet "yes!" under his breath. Adora handed the treasure back and picked up the pails from the floor.

“But I’m still holding on to evening training...so you should probably hurry up!”

+++

“I’d like to apologize for my outburst yesterday.”

“Oh. That’s fine.” Glimmer stood awkwardly at eir door, waving her hand behind her back to signal Bow’s exit. It seemed their discussion on his discovery would have to come to an early end. “Really, it’s alright.” Bow discreetly made his way to the window, avoiding the sliver that Angella peeked through.

“Is it alright if I could come inside? There are a few things I believe I should tell you.” Crash! Glimmer’s heart jumped to her throat.

“That vase was new!” Ey thought.

Angella stepped forward. She attempted to push the door open but stumbled backwards with an opposing foot forward from the princess. “What was that? Glimmah is there someone else in there with you?”

“No!” Glimmer yelled, “There is...no one...else...in here,” Ey spoke in exaggerated syllables and dragged out vowels as if to buy time, but Angella’s face pinched in displeasure.

“Glimmah if one of your friends-” Ey zoned out mid sentence, beginning to ring a spell from her fingers.

“No it's just a pigeon I promise.” The circles of light grew from behind her back. *Come on...*

“I don’t appreciate lying young lady.” Angella pushed against the door with her foot once again.

“Really! Look!” Glimmer opened the door to reveal a pigeon pecking at the soil on the window ledge. Angella inspected the room briefly. No one. She found herself at a loss for words.

“Oh...my apologies once again.” Bewilderment still coated her face.

Glimmer followed her into the corridor and closed the door slowly. A snap from a finger and the pigeon turned to specks of light.

“Well I’m meeting up with Bow and Adora today so...I will see you later!” She flashed a smile and bolted off ahead in her casual gown.

“Excuse me? Glimmah you can’t just run off like- You better not be going anywhere near the Woods!”

“We’re not! I promise it will be very much safe Ma!”

“Glimmah if you do anything dangerous-”

“Bye! I love you!”

She couldn’t have dashed down the stairs any faster. Across the balcony, the strips of sunlight trailed on her feet. She could hear the outside calling for her name.

Taking a quick turn to the entrance to grab eir shoes, ey slid down the spiral staircase to the cellar. She caught a whiff of fermented grape and cinnamon, deeming it safe enough to alter into eir mage fit. The light at the end of the tunnel grew ever so slightly with each step and then-

The grass sunk beneath her feet.

“I am so sorry about your vase.” Amber eyes met with rose-tinted ones.

Glimmer sniffed the air. “Of course, you simply owe me a new one.”

The two made their way out of the back courtyard. “Alright how about that long coral one we saw at the pottery the other day?

“Coral? Ew.”

“You had a *huge* coral phase don’t get me started.”

Ey chuckled, “As you wish!”

+++

“We’re here.” She spoke in a solemn tone. “The Whispering Woods, creek of demons…” The words themselves struck fear in knights, soldiers, monumental heroes of the past. Glimmer gazed upon the emerald trees and leafy path in front of em, in the distance a dark abyss.

“Aha! We’re actually here!” Glimmer burst into glee. Violet blitzed down the path and before Bow could calm her down, she pranced in her magic. Circles of light appearing in the air as she glittered from each, appearing as a string of light between intervals. It had been like watching a resplendent show of fireworks.

“Glimmer?! What are you doing? You’ll give us away to every single predator in this forest!” Bow’s voice cracked. She disappeared into a halo of light.

“Boop!” Bow jumped at the touch on his shoulder, to which a mischievous mage giggled behind him and disappeared into light again.

“Wow, you’ve gotten really good at this teleportation...magic...thing.” Adora stuttered..

Glimmer rose up from a halo on the ground. She bowed like an entertainer at the closing of eir show. “Thank you Adora...and calm down Bow. There’s way too much light for them to even try us here. Besides, I haven’t been able to use half of my spells in months.”

A scheming sword weilder considered the thought next to Bow, shrugging it off a few times before curling his lips into a smirk.

“Ohohoho, if we’re really showing off magic, wait until you see what the sword can do now thanks to my brave *curiosity* .” Adora and Glimmer practically raced each other further into the woods, shooting out bolts of magic and light and making enough noise to even shake the distant birds into flight. All Bow could do was simply watch, then carry on into the thicket with immeasurable regret.

The further they travelled the less paved road lay before them. More trees sprout up from the ground.

“Shadow demons, reckless horde soldiers, mysterious spies...oh this is going to be so good!”

“How many times do I have to emphasise we’re not trying to get killed? May I remind you two, hence you forgot, that getting killed is *not* fun.”

“What happened to the oh-so-tough guys I had a drink with last night? Hey, if you can’t take them on I have *plenty* of tricks up my sleeve!” With glittery sparks forming by eir knuckles, ey punched the air. They emitted a loud twinkling sound with each blow, which in turn led a frantic Bow to clasp her hands in his.

“Yes you do, and I believe you should keep them there until further notice.” He shed his hold and glued his eyes to the map again.

Glimmer groaned. They had traveled dangerously deep into the forest by now. Little light squeezed through the vine ceilings, and the path had disintegrated into mossy tree roots and slippery rocks.

“So how did you find this one?” Glimmer asked. She took an interest in completing the meeting they had yet to finish earlier and eyed the map from behind Bow.

“It more so found me.” Across the page were red markings on top of a broad etch of the forest itself. One clear red cross stood out from the rest. It was hard to tell at first, but once Glimmer brought eirself closer, she noticed. “After pinpointing the landmarks we’ve touched on so far, I realized the First Ones didn’t try to scatter their tech, everything’s set up in a huge terrestrial pentagon...”

There he went, getting lost in that studious frenzy that amazed Glimmer more than usual lately. Explaining the intricacies of his discovery and the path ahead of them. He knew the forest like the back of his hand. Why, it was still his home after all.

“...I wish I could guarantee I’m right, but we’ll likely find something on the wa-“

“Eep!”

“Glimmer!” Two knights flinged themselves towards the mage, hands gripped on their weapons.

“Ugh, I’m fine!” Eir roar had been a perfect enough response for them to step back. A shredded vine flung to the floor from the smack of her hand. She buried her face under eir hood and tucked her arms as she paced ahead furiously, “Just got caught off guard oka-”

A sudden odour defiled her senses. Tears pooled at her lids and ey covered eir nose in disgust. It was an agonizing stench of rotting meat and rust. Glimmer stepped back from what she revealed behind the ivy curtain and in her automatic movement, all ey could feel were the two gentle hands embracing her fall.

“Woah Glimmer, are you alright?” Adora took note of the horror in Glimmer’s eyes and followed her gaze ahead.

The buzzing of flies suddenly blared in a torturous song. Millions of skin-crawling maggots swarmed in and out of the carcass. The exposed bones, from its antlers to its feet, dripped with a black

substance like machine oil. Somehow, even just from the remains of the deer, Glimmer could make out the cry of anguish that was still frozen on its face, and that was only more suffocating than the smell its bloodied meat left off. Eir horror soon grew into a loathsome repugnance as her eyes narrowed. Adora didn't respond.

"I-" Glimmer choked the words back. She reached out for it, uncertain of her intentions. The maggots swarmed faster as her fingers instinctively glowed gold.

"We don't need to see this. Let's go." Bow snapped her out of the spell and brought out Kowl to his front. Had he any more patience to inspect the corpse, perhaps he would have noticed the stun that swept over both her and Adora from his ice cold response, Glimmer most of all.

She lifted her knees off the dirt and watched him avert his eyes.

Bow knew the woods like the back of his hand. He knew them too well.

Their little escapade couldn't have possibly gotten any worse. It was nowhere near the same as when they were fresh into adulthood, but alas, with one last glance of the carcass, had Glimmer spotted a heart, neatly etched into one of it's right ribs.

No one spoke for a while.

+++

Adora lagged behind, surveying every shadow between each branch. His armoured hand sat steady on the sheath strapped to his belt and the device marked on Bow's map lingered on in his thoughts. How many times would he be haunted with the discoveries of something so familiar to him, but completely foreign

at the same time. And what did this mean for him? No, for She-ra. The beat of whatever organ in his chest throbbed in his ears.

“God, shut up.”

“Something on your mind?”

“Huh? Oh no.” He flashed Bow a reassuring smile. How did he get so ahead? Where was Glimmer? He spotted the dark, violet tuft of hair to his right and his hold noticeably loosened. “Just high with the adrenaline of adventure.”

Leaves rustled. Adora was quick to answer with a firm grip on his sword. Suddenly every shadow in the wood only appeared more abysmal.

“It sounds like we have company.” He murmured.

“Are you sure? It doesn’t sound big enough to be a-“

“Shh, we should take it by surprise.” Adora led the way. Bow stole a glance towards Glimmer who too seemed out of tune. She creeped along lifelessly.

They leaned against an array of trees. Purple light bounced from Glimmer’s cheeks from the incantation she drew out. Adora caught her attention this time, the blonde hairs on the back of his neck stood up.

The Heart. *The Heart.* She shook the image out of her head vigorously.

“On three…”

“One.”

“Two”

“Three! AHHH!” The three charged.

It rustled the leaves under its weight again, but instead to prop its head up from its meal. The team stood cemented in their battle stance. There in the middle of the small clearing lay their small, furry, white-tailed foe.

The hare sniffed the breeze, as if to only rub its tender being further into the wounds of Adora’s miscalculation. It carried on with its leafy feast.

“Aw...” Glimmer cooed, dropping eir defence, “ When was the last time I saw a bunny?”

Adora followed, pinching his nose on his way up. “Ugh, of course. My mistake.” Glimmer’s head was cleared thanks to the fluffy encounter, but Adora carried himself just the same. His friends looked cautiously as he marched ahead, Bow being the first to follow and study from afar.

“It’s dangerous here you know?” The mage rummaged through one of eir pouches for a carrot stick, assuming the horses back at the stables would be just fine with one less.

Further up, Bow caught up with his ghostly friend. “Hey, Adora. What’s going on?” His tug pulled Adora out of his rush. Even through the soldier front Adora put up, he could still spot the light gray circles under his eyes.

“Everything’s okay, Bow.” He sweeped his hand off his forearm.

“Um guys…”

“We’re here to have fun remember? Find something worthwhile...” The words came out more panicked then cheerful.

“Adora...Bow...”

“You don’t exactly look like you’re having a good time.”

The two flinched from the sharp grip.

“Ow! Glimmer, what-“ Adora paused. Her petite frame was clouded by a broad shadow...his too. Ey looked upwards, her face burning pale with fright. Adora’s cerulean eyes nervously followed.

“Oh…”

Gabriel IV

“What is that?!"

“It’s a Shadow Demon, what do you think?!”

“That size?!” Curtains of ivy. Greenery for miles. Black spikes jutted from the ground and sent a rippling tremor throughout the terrain. Glimmer yelped. The quake had the three tipping briefly but they kept ahead.

“I’m quite sure I was feeding a rabbit just a second ago, not a Shadow Demon!” Glimmer teethed.

“Because it tricked us!”

“Excuse me?!”

“Less talking! More running!” Bow and Glimmer were swept off their feet by one armored and one gloved arm. Adora rushed from behind and hoisted them up from their torsos.

The beast struck again with almost perfect precision, which earned a screech from all of them. Adora eyed a clearing in the distance. Leaves crunched beneath his feet. Dodging, ducking. Skidding over rock. Bow and Glimmer held tightly to his waist.

Adora felt the skin-crawling presence of their foe. It was fast. It hunted them down willfully, tearing down the forest and leaving a trace of destroyed woodlands. A cold chill passed through his spine. The eerie murmurs grew louder. Its shadow grew larger.

The clearing wasn’t far. They would make it.

When vines snapped. The ground slid. Leaves pummeled with them down the incline. Glimmer felt the burn of friction on eir back. Ey came face to face with soil when she finally opened her eyes, thorns stuck to her skin.

The rush to her head blurred eir sight, but Adora and Bow lay on the floor ahead of her, struggling on their forearms.

The shadow beast did not roar or howl, it was a choir of whispers, of ghosts that had failed to escape it.

It slithered down the rocky incline with its revolving limbs. It would only take seconds for it to reach them. Red lambent veins were already visible through its faceless, apparitional form. Rock, forest and more rock. Not enough sunlight and too many shadows to keep it at bay. They were cornered.

Adora stubbornly lifted himself up, pulling out his sword. "You two go on ahead. I'll keep this thing busy." It streaked faster.

"Alone?!" Glimmer and Bow synched. Bow had managed to get up, with one hand already reaching for Kowl. "Adora but-"

"Yes alone! Now go!"

Bow stared in disbelief. Burying his worry, he helped Glimmer, who was just as reluctant to keep going.

They ran into the center of the thicket again. He looked ahead, but Glimmer couldn't stop herself from looking back habitually. Her blood raced faster each time the trees shook, some were even knocked to the ground...but this was Adora right? Adora could handle this.

And from the corner of eir eye she watched her best friend get thrown to the ground.

"Adora!" Glimmer poofed out of Bow's hands.

"Leave my people alone!"

The sky cracked. Glimmer, the princess of Brightmoon, outlawed mage to eir own mother's law...his first real best friend in the strange place…

...punched the shadow demon.

Eir hair sparkled like iridescent pearls hid in eir curls. A blinding light followed by a loud glittering sound, Glimmer smashed her fist into the head of the monster. A split second was what it could've been, but the moment would have never escaped Adora's memory. Ey vanished from the air.

The beast lobbed its body with half of its upper burned off from the hit. Adora stared from below as the edges of its gash sparkled against the sun, to which it screamed.

"Haha! Adora did you see that?!" An eager voice cheered from behind. The mage's joy filtered quickly as the sun eclipsed behind a foggy entity. The ground cracked under the beast's arm. A confident aim for the mage.

And only an arm's length away the dust cleared to reveal a mostly unharmed target. Glimmer groaned in pain on the ground. Weakly, she lifted herself on one elbow to find Adora propped on her waist. He saved her...again...

It screeched behind them. "What do you think you're doing?!" He barked. They both got up quickly when the beast realized it missed.

It turned the half of its head to them and retreated its limb.

"Well, I'm trying to *help* you!"

It raised its body to strike again.

"Do you see that thing?! You could've gotten hurt!" The sword slashed through the beast's arm as it crashed down. It shrieked in anguish, jutting out spikes from its body into the ground.

"A thank you would be nice!" Glimmer hurled an orb of light. It seemed to put the monster in a shocked daze. She approached eir friend. "What's wrong Adora? You've been tense ever since we got here."

Coal coloured spikes shot up from the ground. The volatile eruption launched Glimmer against the nearest bark and Adora across the floor.

The knight temporarily lost his bearings. He coughed, “Glimmer!”

A whistle and a boom. The heavens exploded. The beast crashed to the ground.

“Adora, Glimmer! Are you okay?” Bow rushed in on the scene, an arrow readily nocked in his bow.

Sat under the tree, Glimmer hunched over eir arm. Ey couldn’t concentrate on rounding up another spell. Not when eir better aiming arm had hurt like such. Purple glitter trickled like flashes of lightning between eir fingers.

He spotted her leaned against the tree. Adora rushed to attend to em. “Glimmer I said-”

“Alone?” She looked up at him, utterly disappointed and vexed, “When have we ever left each other to fight *alone?* ” Adora blinked, stupefied. Glimmer’s face curled into an expression more sympathetic, more patient. “ You’re *stressed* . I can tell from a mile away. Nothing is like it was or should be. I get it. That’s why you need to let us be there *with* you now more than ever.” In the backdrop, the whistling of the arrows and the thunder from the explosives could still be heard.

“You’re not alone. You never will be.”

His azure eyes softened. Adora nodded in a new purposeful agreement.

The heavens exploded again.

“Okay I may be running out of gunpowder arrows…” Bow, Glimmer and Adora were backed tightly into a corner. Gashed and almost torn to shreds, the beast still rose, hopping between the shaded areas of the forest as to regain parts of itself.

“Why can’t this thing just die already?” Adora readied himself with his sword. The shadow demon just kept reforming itself. There was no telling how much it would take to get rid of it. It only remained ruptured at the point Glimmer struck it. It gave eir an idea.

“I could get us out of here.”

“Okay...How?” Bow asked among loading another arrow. Glimmer almost appeared desperate, but cloaked it behind a dour demeanor. “Oh... *with that* .”

“All three of us?!” Adora shouted back. Left. Right. Center. The sword diced through every spike shooting toward him.

“We won’t make it out otherwise.”

“I know but,” The beast held a raging tantrum. Adora dashed in front of Glimmer, blocking an attack mid air with his sword. The mage stood up. “How much is that going to cost you?”

“What?!” Glimmer ducked at the nearby explosion.

“There is no magic like that without a cost! What’s the condition?!” The beast lifted every one of its arms in the air.

“I haven’t exactly practiced with multiple people. I could get the spell completely wrong and teleport us right off a cliff or get us all stuck in a slow, spiraling death trap between the access points! Alternatively, it works!”

“Sounds fine by me!” He lashed the arm to the side, stepping into the circle already drawn on the ground. The beast was furious and flung itself toward them, splitting its face in two. Adora felt a tight grip on his hand.

“ ‘et Flü gel avi les!” A void of white quickly flashed.

Glimmer opened her eyes to a clear blue. A sinking feeling in her stomach formed and a heavy weight pushed on her chest. She

moved one finger, checking if the spell had damaged her mobility, or if her arm was still there at all...but it responded. Slowly, ey turned her head. She was on the ground. “Oh...oh! It worked! We’re alive!” It dawned on em that ey had no idea where the ‘we’ in that statement lay. “Bow?! Adora?!”

“Barely…” Bow rolled on the floor, clutching to his stomach.

“We made it.” Adora had already recovered from the spell and ambled around instead. He looked to Glimmer like he had just spotted a ghost. “You teleported us right to the site.”

“I...did?”

Recovery followed quickly. They all marveled awestruck. Broken limestone columns, a massive octagonal carving beneath their feet, and the evidence of aging as vines and weeds curled out from every crack in the architecture. The floor had been barely visible under all the foliage.

“Yea, I did…”

“But, I’m not seeing any ancient artifacts lying around.” Adora gloomed. Glimmer wandered aimlessly on the site, anxiously looking for a podium.

“Maybe because it’s underground.” Heads turned. Bow brought his foot up to one of the scattered pillars and it shifted. A quiet roar sounded as the stone floor parted in two to reveal an L-shaped staircase.

~

The cut of the stairs met with a never ending darkness. Adora gestured to Glimmer. “Your cue.”

Ey nodded. With her hand laid out ahead of her, small glittery sparks jumped from her palm. They pulsed at their minimal, struggling to alight any further. “ Come on,” she teethed, a numbing headache growing with the spell. It floundered.

Bow tapped her shoulder. “Don’t push yourself. You know very well what will happen if you use too much magic. We can find something else to-”

“I know, I know. Just let me handle this.” Ey snapped her fingers and ignited another orb of sparks. She chewed on eir teeth until finally, the halls lit up under a purple glow.

Rows and rows of writing, years of discoveries and a preserved civilization through the grace of time.

“What does it say?” Glimmer asked. It didn’t take much for Adora to have his eyes fixed on the symbols, calculating each one carefully.

“Nothing. Seems everything on the walls are just decorative.” Glimmer pouted at her missed chance for a new spell. “Maybe I’ll find something further up.”

So they followed the trail further up, half keeping their alert on the path, and half gawking over the art on the wall. Adora slowed down at one specific carving. He lingered over the figure with a circular marking on their head and a sword raised to the sky...and then the smaller figures at their feet, reaching up with praise. He cringed.

“Alright, the charade is over. What the hell happened back there? And ‘Shadow Demon’ alone will not do for an answer,” ordered Glimmer. She resembled a part of eir mother when ey spoke, save for her crude choice of words. “ *I’d never hear the end of that lecture,”* She thought.

Bow trailed his fingers over the relief symbols. “We’re just as lost as you are. I’ve never come across a demon smart or advanced enough to put up a trap, let alone shape shift entirely.”

“It wasn’t shape shifting. That rabbit was dead. It was using the corpse, like a puppet. ” Adora answered monotonously, “I thought that would be the obvious takeaway from this…”

“Okay. So the brainless monsters that are trying to eat us alive are getting…smarter. Great.” Glimmer dragged the last syllable to the ground. Adora had no answer. Neither did Bow...for a while...

“But against us they don’t stand a chance right?”

“Who? You two? Seriously again with this-“

“No all three of us.” Bow ruffled her hair. “What would the best friend squad be without a bit of sparkle?”

“Huh, real- er, I mean, *exactly* ! I was awesome!” The purple glow boomed brightly on her last word. “And Adora was all like *‘argh no! Glimmer what are you doing’?’”*

“I just got a little worried. It’s been a while *o-kay.”* He muttered playfully under his breath, " It looks like someone’s gonna have a lot to say tonight at Three’s.”

Glimmer tilted eir head back and smirked. “And I will! There’s no way I’m letting this go.”

Glimmer tripped back when she bumped into it...or him. One arm stopped em from walking any further. She shrugged at Bow, but he only answered with a side glance to what waited ahead of them.

An expansive circular hall. The relief-filled walls were cracked. Weeds and vines poked out of every nook possible. Ivy hung from above through the broken glass ceiling. “ *So that’s how Bow knew it was underground,”* ey thought . Light traveled in from the same broken, stained glass in a berry blue. It kissed the empty plinth in the center.

“I suppose this is it right? We’re at the end of the tunnel,” she wondered.

Her eyes followed the plinth down to the floor. As decorative as it had been, each symbol ingrained in the coal gray stone could

have been cloaking either a deadly trick or the turquoise brick road to the middle. “Anyone have any ideas?”

Adora did. He marched straight ahead.

“Adora be careful. This place could be loaded with traps.” Bow watched in horror.

“This place is more than a millennium old, almost everything has turned to dust. Besides what’s the worst that could happen to me?” Adora grinned pompously back to Bow, “I die?”

Glimmer snorted.

“That’s not funny,” Bow remarked.

“Agreed. It’s *mostly* not funny,” she added. Adora tiptoed along the central floor’s markings.

“It’s not funny at all.”

While the other two argued over Adora’s questionable sense of humour, he found a slit right at the head of the plinth. He had done this too many times before.

The sword fell into the incision with a thundering echo. The hall quaked and they waited uneasily. It stopped. “See, no tr-“

Fling! Thin gold hairs draped off and Adora felt the sudden sting in his cheek. The arrow jutted out of the back wall. “Okay, now there shouldn’t be any traps.”

Glyphs on the floor lit a fluorescent blue. Each vein pumping back to their source, the Runestone glowing in the swords chest, the ‘Runestone of Souls’.

He looked back, struggling to keep the smile from forming on his lips as Bow and Glimmer assured him on. Adora restlessly removed the stone seal that appeared. His breath escaped him at the sight.

“It’s gone.”

The word circled the room twice.

“What?!” They both cried.

“What do you *mean* it’s gone?!” Glimmer continued.

“I *mean* the mysterious First Ones artifact we travelled *all* this way for is either one, invisible, or two, completely missing!”

All three of them stood absolutely stunned. Glimmer shook her head in disbelief. “That- That wouldn’t make any sense. You’re the only one with the sword, the key I- how would anyone be able to get to it before us?” Her words came out unstable and shaky.

The answer was clear, but no one wished to say it.

Adora stared at the empty space. “The horde can’t do much with just one First Ones relic,” he said, “If they have it, we still have the sword, the Runestone as well as all the documents back at the library.”

“So...we failed?” Bow and Adora exchanged looks. Glimmer didn’t wait for an answer. She turned back down the hall.

There were whispers...or calls for em from behind. Ey couldn’t tell. The purple orb in her hand blew to the size of her head. Again, with the horde. Another victory for the horde.

“Glimmer...”

An extra step forward...for the horde.

“Glimmer calm down please!”

And *nothing* from them.

“Glimmer stop! You’ll-” Piercingly, an ache to her head blew eir sight white and the orb exploded into dust.

+++

“Okay, enough with the cold cloth. You’re just gonna make em sick.” The voice was barely audible against the ringing.

“Sorry if I’m panicking?!” And another. “I’m just trying to regulate her body temperature!” A load of air filled her lungs. Her eyes fluttered open and there they were, hovering above her like medical students in an almshouse. Little was clear yet but even in an insensible state she could recognize the high pitched voice crack.

“Glimmer! Thank Serenia you’re okay!” Ey hadn’t even been conscious long enough to discern who had just embraced em, but from the tightness of the hug, it was all too easy to tell.

“Yea, yea. I’m fine Bow. You didn’t have to get all cry-face over me” Ey pushed her head up and off of Adora’s lap, all while still being passionately hugged by Bow. He let go after an awkward minute.

“I’m not-” he sniffed, “I’m not crying…”

It seemed they got out and carried Glimmer to the nearest point safe enough to rest. No First Ones ruins. Only trees.

Adora sighed in relief. “That could have gone differently you know? ” Glimmer vouched to answer, but changed her mind entirely when Adora’s sentiment reminded her of home.

The knight took notice of this and tried a different approach. “But you really saved my tail today so I owe you one.”

“We just missed you. We missed this.”

Her cheeks warmed and the urge to tear up almost engulfed her entirely.

Adora beamed seeing his friends happy (and safe) again but he quickly wiped the smile off his face and looked to the ground. The

involuntary action didn't miss Bow's notice however.

"Awww, Best Friend hug?"

Adora rolled his eyes, but ended up being the first to join in on the big embrace. It was something he needed after all. It was something they all needed.

"I missed you guys too." Glimmer whispered into Adora's shoulder.

The seconds moved. The violent crow of the ravens brought Adora back to his senses. He pushed away from the hug and stood up. "Dusk is about to break. We should leave before we lose all our safe ground here." Glimmer looked up. The clouds were pink and the sky had turned the shade of warm honey. He was right. She didn't want to tread anywhere near the woods at night, especially powerless.

"The Whispering Woods struck fear in the hearts of blood-thirsty gladiators, ancient heroes and the noble warriors of Etheria...but like this? Like this it was alright," She thought. The dear critters and creatures of the forest crawled back to their burrows. The feeble chicks chirped for their mothers to return back to their nests. The squirrels were welcomed by their families as they hid back into their dens. Even for what was proven to be a hostile, destroyed and inhabitable environment, Etheria never seized to make the woods a magical place. She wondered again how magical it would have still been if not perverted by the Horde.

They branched off their original route, taking the safest route Bow could remember. It was not long until they looked to the kingdom silhouette of Brightmoon, far off the green fields and tucked in the mountains.

"Swiftie!" The pale horse neighed joyfully in response. He galloped on the spot before tugging himself in Adora's chest. Adora almost fell backward as the horse knocked his breath out of him, but he

laughed it off and briskly rubbed Swiftwind's head anyway. The other two steads waited patiently amongst the trees.

"I guess it's back to the princess room from here," Glimmer hoisted herself up on Loo-kee, looking despondently at the sharp edge of the castle. "Yah yah!" She flicked on the rein and they began the ride home.

The air was crisp and lull. They passed over the sunflower fields and few rural farms that connected all the way to Thaymor. The sun peaked from the horizon.

"Are you still holding evening training?"

Adora looked back perplexed, as if he had never heard the words before. The memory struck him. "Oh, right. Uh...I'll give the guys the day off. I had a lot of fun today. Might as well rest."

Bow stared at him in waiting. The wait was silent save for the horse trodding.

"You're just going to train on your own."

"I'm just going to train on my own."

The two hadn't noticed Glimmer slowing down on a minor turn. Ey waited atop the hill ominously.

"Hey guys...look."

She gestured further into the distance. Off put by the grave change in mood, Bow and Adora caught up, coming to a harsh stop over the tump.The kingdom silhouette was much less vague but they all squinted for a better view.

Just further below the castle, blurry puffs of dark gray smoke gathered in the sky. Bow's eyes shot wide open.

"It's a-"

“Fire.” The word shuddered in Adora lungs.

Gabriel V

The sky darkened. The wind chilled.

But he rode faster.

“Adora wait!” Steel hooves dug into the grass, rhythm beating like a steady drum.

His knuckles turned white around the reins. “ Lei!” Swift wind answered with a war-calling neigh and a canon pace.

The portcullis was left bare and open. He rode in, overwhelmed by the endless brick sea looking back at him. Blood pulsing, a weightless heartbeat, hunting down the smoke across the village homes. The black smog was his compass.

Like a bloodlust wolf, darting in and out of every cobblestone road until he found it. He found it on the corner-street. The building...or what was left of it, burnt like a red rose.

“Up!” the flames screeched under the water. One villager dispatched from the line.

There was no time to deliberate. Adora followed after dismounting. Many gathered by the barrack’s well, frantically filling as many buckets as possible with water. The villager huffed as they picked the bucket up. Adora took it for himself, as well as another two, and hurried back to the scene.

“Up!” A whisper. And so withered the last flame into mist.

The knight turned pale. Here he was on top of the Brightmoon Administration building. A structure reduced to rubble and ash.

“No! Leave me!” A much older villager shoved opposing hands away, tears dripping from their cheeks. They rushed ahead of Adora, falling to their knees and rummaging through the burnt wood like a street hound searching for scrap food.

“They killed Norwyn! The door was smashed shut! Someone wanted to kill him!”

Static.

Everything fell to the static language of the teal stone. Here he was caught again, between two planes of existence as it fought to take control. *But not this time...it can’t be this time.*

So he remained insentient.

The name played over in his head. The recurring star emblems on the group’s uniform was the only thing he could see. Everything else was either flushed out of his conscience, or not decipherable to him. Not even the two figures that swayed closer to him. Whatever they spoke only added to the enigma of syllables in his head. His limbs and muscles turned to liquid.

“The queen would like to speak with you.”

It gave up. The static cleared.

Adora, paralyzed, somehow managed to make out Captain Juliet, who looked more stern than bewailed by the turmoil. The words didn’t make sense. It took him a minute or two to register the phrase.

“ I- Understood.” He shook his head lifelessly.

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The gates whined open. A long winsome lilac rug rolled across the stone floor. Slender braziers hung off the ivory columns, letting the shadows dance between the bas-reliefs on the walls while lighting the room under a splendid warm hue. Gold leaf adorned drapery in the same colour as the rug covered the windows. The empty night sky looked back at them from the remaining window, an opulent piece of architecture crowning the hall.

But at the very end of the throne room, standing poised in front of her regal oak throne embedded with jewels was Angella, cemented in terror.

“Where were you?” Bow and Adora kneeled. Glimmer remained standing but dropped her eyes to the floor.

“Where were you three?” She asked again. This time her words came out less composed, edging on anxiety and anger. Bow took note of how Glimmer dug her nails into eir tights.

“Your majesty I-”

“I apologize on behalf of all three of us.” Adora’s voice sliced through the archer’s exposition. He spoke with deep sincerity in the monotone voice others knew. “I insisted on going out to the Whispering Woods in search of a relic from the First Ones. Bow and...the princess, were only kind enough to offer assistance. I take fault for not seeing how irresponsible it was of me to not decline the offer.” He paused.

“Especially for eir majesty.”

Glimmer dug deeper.

Angella’s temper simmered down to something more contained. She buried her feelings, composed herself. “Very well. The rest of you are dismissed. Adora, you stay.”

“Wait Ma-” The words shot out before she could think.

“Glimmah go to your room.”

“Alright, I understand you’re angry and you have every right to be, but maybe if you’d just listen I could-”

“Glimmah! Room! Now!” Angella’s rage erupted.

Glimmer lowered her hands that reached out to her mother. Her face twitched in anger, in hesitancy, in sadness. She bit on her

bottom lip before sprinting up to the stairs. Angella watched em go wistfully.

Bow gave his last bow, taking a quick, indebted look at Adora and nodded. He glanced back upon being escorted out.

Adora remained with one knee on the ground.

Overlooking the throne room, Glimmer stormed across the mezzanine. She was not going to her room. Not again.

And if there was one thing the princess had mastered, it was diverting attention. Even in her boiling fury she blinked the hot tears away and crouched behind the balustrade to listen.

"I can tell when you lie to me Adora. Your voice is still shaky. " Her mom spoke solemnly. Adora bit his teeth. "But since you've decided to take the fall, perhaps I should address you first."

Adora still kept his knee low on the carpeted ground. She let out a humoured sigh, "You may rise, Adora." He followed his impulse to look up perplexed before reminding himself of proper etiquette, standing, no questions asked.

"Adora," The words came out quiet, desperate even, but no less impactful, "You've done all you have for Brightmoon...but I'm afraid the fighting, the scouting ends here."

Adora cocked his head in confusion, "Apologies for my impudence but if you'd care to explain your majesty…"

"The horde has not only grown stronger but has managed to infiltrate Brightmoon. Every mistake we make, every loose end we leave unattended is a victory for the horde from this moment onwards. We've lost enough to them...so I've terminated any further expeditions."

"I'm not sure I understand-"

“There will be no more attacks. There will be no more *field trips* .” She inhaled. “Brightmoon has lost enough lives to the war.”

“I understand I made a mistake in leaving my post unguarded-“

“This is no longer regarding you Adora. I’ve made my choice long before this accident. This only goes to show I have made the right one.”

Adora remembered all the defenseless villages that were left scattered across Etheria, the First Ones ruins that were still left to be found...Lighthope.

“But my Queen that would only make us a sitting target and- and there are still villages and kingdoms out there. If let on their own the Horde would find no difficulty in conquering them, only making them stronger. Their setting us u-”

“I will be meeting with the guild next week to discuss the specifics. That is my proposal. I have no other.” It wasn’t working. Adora watched Angella turn away, his head racing for the right words.

“Then I’ll go. On my own expedition. I’ll find out how they’ve managed to intercept the woods and infiltrate Brightmoon.”

Angella turned back. Less interested and more concerned by what she heard. “That sounds

dangerous, Adora...”

“I’m made for this. I *really* do apologize but I can’t let myself sit here knowing the Horde is planning something different right under our noses. If you send me out on my own, minimal to no lives will be lost. I understand where your concern lies, so that is my proposal...and I only wish you let it be heard.”

Angella’s anger dissipated quickly. She stared at Adora bewildered, but distressed by the thought too. Jarred by the honest pleading look Adora let himself show, the queen nodded.

“Thank you your royal highness.” He bowed one last time, waited for his dismissal and made his way out. He skipped on his feet, turning back to the queen. “If you could grace me with your patience as well....Please...do not inform the princess of this.” That agreement had been made quickly through a discreet nod. The knight closed the door gently upon leaving.

Glimmer couldn’t believe what ey heard.

She couldn’t allow it to happen.

Ey dragged herself to her room. The doors shut with a bang as she slid to the floor against them.

Maybe I should just listen. Maybe I should just stay out of all of this. Be a princess, stay in the castle. If we just listened and stayed behind none of this would have happened.

She banged the back of her head against the door.

Just live like a princess.

Just die like a princess.

Opening watery eyes, she spotted an envelope on the floor. The blood wax seal imprinted with the army emblem. She would have almost found it endearing if she was not absolutely sure... *The admirer? Didn’t I throw this out already?* She sniffed, choosing to not let it spoil eir mood any further. And somehow it still landed up in eir curious fingers, seal torn off and letter peaking out. Somehow she still found herself uncurling the paper, discarding the envelope and reading something she had least expected.

‘ *The day comes yet.’* Written in an obsidian black, neatly on the top left corner.

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Cracked bottle in hand, the mage paced across the market square.

“Oh, the strange customer with good eyes.” The sculptor she met earlier that week found her amidst the darkness. She stood outside with her grandfather, a key gripped in one hand. Perfect. “ I hate to say it but we’ve just closed for the day.”

She did it. The sculptor had succeeded in fully setting up; a new magnificent sign hanging off the outer pole and no beams leaning against the workshop. Glimmer had no time to admire the new improved setup however. “Oh, you must be on your way home then...but before that, I’m sorry to take your time. Do you think you could assist me with this?” Ey held up that same stained bottle she bought. This visit with a significant crack running through its neck. “I have...a few important letters to send out today. I’ll repay you graciously for the urgent help.”

Violet eyes looked over the bottle helplessly in the dark. The artist hummed. “Perhaps...please pardon me with a minute or two.” Glimmer waved the sculptor away when she slid back into the shop and out of sight. The facade fell and she dropped to her knees, eye level with the old man that stayed behind. Eir face was as solid as an eagle during its hunt.

“Tell me everything you know about the Heart.”

The First Reading

R*cord**g 102, T***a**nt of *nit ********* R****de*: Gabri*l

Long ago, in a land of great wonders and beasts, there lived a circle of twelve princesses. Each princess ruled and looked over their own kingdom, but most of all, each princess possessed a great source of power, a Runestone. The twelve Runestones granted the princesses the ability to practice divine magic. The magic of Winter, the magic of Flora, the magic of Seas, all pieces in the great chain of being that worked together to create harmony through Etheria.

But this divine magic granted each princess total power over the people, and one princess grew more and more hungry for it. The people grew weary, afraid. With no way to stop her, the princess threatened to obtain Etheria for herself, disrupting the balance kept for millennia. War struck, the eleven kingdoms worked tirelessly to defeat the corrupted princess and eventually, her Runestone was shattered.

All was well, and the princesses managed to restore the balance of what remained, however, the taste of war and the ghost of the fallen twelfth kingdom haunted the people, bringing fear of the princesses that ruled them. Like that, a new power rose, The Horde.

The Horde used fear and doubt of the princesses to grow, setting out on an inquisition to change the regime and have everyone dedicate themselves to one higher being, a god by the name of Prime. They had brought upon worry, but had not grown strong enough to offer a real threat.

Then everything changed.

The Horde set their sights upon Talon Mountains, home to the most revered and magical beings in Etheria, the dragons. Dragons and people lived together in harmony as long as their distance and respect was kept, but the horde labelled them as dangerous beings unaligned with Prime's vision. They hunted every single dragon down, captured those who refused to join their army and took the magical energy of the dragons for themselves. The kingdom burned and the dragons lay extinct. The Horde had become home to the Red Garnet, or, The Runestone of Blood.

They spread their ideas of magic, labelling it uncouth and evil if not cleansed by Prime's light. They invaded kingdoms, destroyed runestones, repurposed magic for their own use and exterminated the princesses…

...one...by...one.

End Notes

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